

Analogue Era Ends

The UK has officially finished its switchover from analogue to digital-terrestrial TV broadcasts, marking the end of an era



ASUS Zenbook

ASUS has expanded its Zenbook line of Ultrabooks, unveiling two new 14-inch and 15-inch models



The Ivy League Of Ultrabooks



The second generation of ultrabooks is here, and the gulf between portability and power has now been bridged!

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We have 14 of the latest ultrabooks pitted against each other, comparing only those that have Intel Ivy Bridge processors. All major manufacturers are participating in this test with their latest ultrabooks. Further, we divided the ultrabooks into smaller categories according to price bands, to make your buying choice simpler.

BUILD, DESIGN & USABILITY

Let us start with the least expensive ultrabook in this test – the Dell Inspiron 14z. Its lid has the dual tone grey and silver finish. Open it up and the dark grey brushed metal tone continues

around the keyboard. The bezel has a similar finish, but in plain matte. Connectivity ports on its left edge have classy covers that hide the ports well. On the right side is the optical drive, this is one of the few ultrabooks that actually offer this, apart from other I/O ports. Despite hailing from the Inspiron series, the classy design and good build quality doesn't betray the lower price tag of the Inspiron 14z. Its keyboard is well spaced out, but when typing briskly, you will see a bit of downward flex towards the middle of the keyboard. Apart from that, the key size, travel and response is very satisfactory. Although good, its touchpad is not the best in terms of response, though.

The Sony Vaio T11 has a rather unique visual appeal. Its small form factor (11.6-inch)

is dressed well in the non-shiny brushed metal finish. When you open the display, the lid pushes down on the back of the laptop, raising it up a bit, and the slight elevation at the back is helpful while typing. Despite the lesser area, the T11's keyboard is nicely spaced out and the key size isn't any smaller. However, the typing experience isn't the best, because of the lesser key travel.

The Acer Timeline Ultra M5 has a basic look. The grey brushed finish is the same on the lid and the frame around the keyboard. It is a bit thicker than most ultrabooks, due to the optical drive. You have to reach behind the display to get to the USB, Ethernet and HDMI. Its keyboard is comfortable to use, with good key placement and adequate travel. Its overall build quality is good, there's no flex.

For the Toshiba Satellite U840, it is a case of two halves – good and bad. Its lid and the palm-rest area has some flex, but it looks good, thanks to the premium brushed metal finish. The keyboard sports flatter keys, with less than perfect key travel. It takes time getting used to that, and also the slightly smaller key dimensions. There is adequate gap between the keys, and the touchpad response is among the better ones. However, a little more effort on Toshiba's part could have ensured a premium finish for the U840.

If you are willing to spend ₹60k on an ultrabook, there is none built better than the HP Envy 4-1002tx. A generous amount of aluminum is used on the HP Envy 4, which makes it look more expensive than it actually is. Its colour combina-